

Etienne Abassi, Ph.D.

Date of birth: Dec. 5th 1989 | **Citizenship:** French | **Gender:** Male | **Languages:** French, English, Spanish | **Phone:** (+1) 438 365 3110
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CURRENT AFFILIATIONS

- International laboratory for Brain, Music and Sound Research (*BRAMS*) – Montréal, Canada (brams.org)
- Centre for Research on Brain, Language and Music (*CRBLM*) – Montréal, Canada (mcgill.ca/brain-language-music)
- Centre for Interdisciplinary Research in Music Media and Technology (*CIRMMT*) – Montréal, Canada (cirmmt.org)
- Montréal Neurological Institute (*The Neuro*) – McGill University, Montréal, Canada (mcgill.ca/neuro)

EDUCATION

2017 – 2021 | **Ph.D. -- Neurosciences** | Claude Bernard Lyon University, France
Thesis: The two-body dyad in visual perception: a new category of social objects

2015 – 2017 | **Master -- Biomedical Sciences: Neurosciences & Behavioral Sciences** | Caen University, France
Thesis: Neurofunctional basis of non-verbal body language perception in dance

2012 – 2015 | **Bachelor -- Human Sciences: Psychology & Neuropsychology** | Montpellier University, France
Thesis: Synesthesia, a novel approach for cognitive remediation

2008 – 2010 | **Higher National Diploma (BTS) -- IT & Software Development** | EPSI Montpellier, France

ACADEMIC EXPERIENCE

2022 – Current | **Postdoctoral Researcher** | McGill University, Montréal, Canada
Topic: Enhancing music perception through vibrotactile feedback: Training-induced plasticity and Neural mechanisms — with Prof. Robert Zatorre
Laboratory: The Auditory Cognitive Neuroscience Laboratory (zlab.mcgill.ca) | Montreal Neurological Institute (*The Neuro*)

2017 – 2021 | **Philosophiae Doctor (Ph.D.)** | French National Centre For Scientific Research (CNRS), Lyon, France
Topic: Visual processing of social scenes: Behavioral effects and brain mechanisms — with Dr. Liuba Papeo
Laboratory of Cognitive Neuropsychology and Development (liubapapeolab.com/research) | Institut des Sciences Cognitives Marc Jeannerod

2017 | **Master internship** | Maastricht University, Netherlands
Topic: Visual processing of movements in dance: Neuro-functional bases — with Dr. Beatrice de Gelder
Brain and emotion laboratory (beatricedegelder.com/research) | Maastricht university

2016 | **Master internship** | Caen University, France
Topic: Anxiety at different stages of Alzheimer's disease: Cognitive and brain correlates — with Dr. Gaël Chetelat
Laboratory: *Multimodal neuroimaging and Lifestyle in Aging and Alzheimer's disease* (neuropresage.fr) | Cycleron

2015 | **Bachelor internship** | Montpellier, France
Topic: Chronic neuropathic pain: modulation of the neuronal FLT3 receptor in rodents — with Dr Jean Valmier / Dr Cyril Rivat
Laboratory of Somesthesia and Physiopathology (inmfrance.com) | Institute for Neurosciences of Montpellier (INM - INSERM)

FELLOWSHIPS

2025-2026 | **Brenda Milner Postdoctoral fellowship (\$40 000)** | Montreal Neurological Institute (*The Neuro*), Montréal, Canada

2022-2024 | **Fondation for Hearing (FPA) Postdoctoral fellowship (90 000 €)** | Fondation pour l'Audition, Paris, France

OTHER WORK EXPERIENCES

2011 – 2015 | **IT Technician / Network Administrator** | Occitanie En Scène, Montpellier, France
Software and hardware maintenance / System and network administration

2010 – 2011 | **IT Technician** | Research Institute for Sustainable Development (IRD OCCITANIE), Montpellier, France
Software and hardware maintenance

TRAINING & PROFESSIONAL DEVELOPMENT

2026 - *Touch beyond sound: Haptics and tactile enhancements for music and inclusion* - CIRMMT, Montréal, Canada (*Workshop*)

2026 - *Computer Music: Artificial Intelligence in Creative Context* - University of Montreal, Canada (*Courses*)

2025 - *Immersive Sound Creation* – Société des Arts Technologiques (SAT), Montréal, Canada

2025 - *Scripting for Immersive Experiences* – Société des Arts Technologiques (SAT), Montréal, Canada (*Courses*)

2025 - *Generative Audio for Music-Making (GAMMa)* - CIRMMT, Montréal, Canada (*Workshop*)

2025 - *Montreal Open Tools Symposium* (SpeechBrain, GrFNN, SocialEyes, ...) - CRBLM, Montréal, Canada (*Workshops*)

2024 - *The Best of Haptic Worlds* - CIRMMT, Montréal, Canada (*Workshop*)

2024 - *Tech-Enhanced Music Education* - CIRMMT, Montréal, Canada (*Symposium*)

2024 - *Living in the Acoustic Environment* - Acoustical Society of America, Ottawa, Canada (*Courses*)

2023 - *Composing and Performing with Digital Musical Instruments* - CIRMMT, Montréal, Canada (*Workshop*)

2023 - *Exploring Machine Learning, Artificial Creativity and Human Musicality* - CIRMMT, Montréal, Canada (*Workshop*)

2022 - *Advanced Music Production with Ableton Live* - Fastlane, Montpellier, France (*Courses*)

2022 - *Bases of Electronic Music Production* - EMS Electronic Music School, Berlin, Germany (*Courses*)

TEACHING & ACADEMIC CONFERENCES

2024 - *Category-selective representation of relationships in visual cortex* - Society for Neuroscience conference, Chicagoo, USA (*Talk*)

2024 - *Multi-Modal Perception of Social Interactions* - Feindel Brain and Seminar series, McGill University, Canada (*Conference*)

2024 - *Influence of social and semantic context in processing speech in noise* – ARO MidWinter meeting, Anaheim, USA (*Talk*)

2021 - *Social perception: from faces to interactions* - Master NeuroConferences, Lyon University, France (*Course*)

2020 - *The two-body configuration in visual perception* - Visual Science Society conference, Virtual meeting (*talk*)

2019 - *Introduction to Multivariate Pattern Analysis (MVPA)* - Neurosciences and Cognition Doctoral School, Lyon, France (*Workshop*)

STUDENT SUPERVISION

2026 - Leila Meisenbach Lambiri - Bachelor (*McGill University*)
2025 - Eli Shlimovitz - PhD (*McGill University*)
2025 - Nadia MacGregor - Bachelor (*McGill University*)
2025 - Jesse Millman - Bachelor (*McGill University*)
2024 - Arielle Rabinowitz - PhD (*McGill University*)
2024 - Jess Chittock - Bachelor (*McGill University*)
2024 - Aarti Advani - Bachelor (*McGill University*)
2024 - Iza Tacala - Bachelor (*McGill University*)
2024 - Mai Ababneh - Bachelor (*McGill University*)
2023 - Violette Munin - Master (*Lyon 1 University*)
2018 - Xi Wang - Bachelor (*Lyon 1 University*)

SCIENTIFIC REVIEWING AND CONSULTING

2025 - *Annals of the New York Academy of Sciences*, New York, USA (*Manuscript Review*)
2025 - *The Inners Designers*, Paris, France (*Private Consulting*)
2024 - *National Science Foundation (NSF)*, Arlington, USA (*Grant Review*)
2024 - *Imaging Neuroscience*, MIT Press, Cambridge, USA (*Manuscript Review*)
2023 - *Neuroimage*, Elsevier, Amsterdam, Netherlands (*Manuscript Review*)
2023 - *Nature Scientific Reports*, Springer, London, UK (*Manuscript Review*)
2023 - *The Journal of Neuroscience*, Washington, USA (*Manuscript Review*)
2022 - *The Journal of Neuroscience*, Washington, USA (*Manuscript Review*)

PUBLIC OUTREACH & SCIENCE COMMUNICATION

2025 - *Introduction to sound synthesis and electronic music production* – XLTRAX Academy, Québec, Canada (*Workshop*)
2025 - *Brain, Bass & Music* – XLTRAX Academy, Québec, Canada (*Public Conference*)
2025 - *Introduction to sound synthesis and electronic music production* - Timeless festival, Québec, Canada (*Workshop*)
2025 - *Brain, Bass & Music* - Timeless festival, Québec, Canada (*Public Conference*)
2024 - *Brain, Bass & Music* - Future Forest festival, New Brunswick, Canada (*Public Conference*)
2024 - *Brain, Bass & Music* - Lucioles festival, Québec, Canada (*Public Conference*)
2023 - *Brain, Bass & Music* - Timeless festival, Québec, Canada (*Public Conference*)
2021 - *Magnetic resonance imaging in neuroscience* - Brain week, Lyon, France (*Public Conference*)

PUBLICATIONS

Abassi, E., & Zatorre, R. (2026). The representation of speech conversations in the human auditory cortex: role of social and semantic factors. *Cerebral Cortex*. <https://doi.org/10.1093/cercor/bhag023>

Hébrard, S., **Abassi, E.**, Coffey, E., Merino, S. G., Zatorre, R., & Cohen, L. (2026). Brain Specialization for Music and Word Reading: a High-Resolution Precision Imaging Study. *European Workshop on Cognitive Neuropsychology*. <https://cnrs.hal.science/hal-05560047>

Abassi, E., & Zatorre, R. (2025). Influence of social and semantic contexts on phonetic encoding in naturalistic conversations. *The Journal of the Acoustical Society of America*. <https://doi.org/10.1121/10.0039532>

Goldford, L., Noble, J., Knight, J.M., **Abassi, E.**, Couturier, G., Nestorova, T., Traube, C. (2025). Evaluating Vocality in Orchestral and Mixed Works. *ACTOR's Timbre and Orchestration Resource*. <https://doi.org/10.5281/zenodo.15729385>

Munin, V., **Abassi, E.**, Beuriat, P. A., & Papeo, L. (2025). The effects of spatial relations and motion information in social scene perception. *Scientific Reports*. <https://doi.org/10.1038/s41598-025-07870-1>

Abassi, E., Bognár, A., de Gelder, B., Giese, M., Isik, L., Lappe, A. & Vogels, R. (2024). Neural Encoding of Bodies for Primate Social Perception (2024). *Journal of Neuroscience*. <https://doi.org/10.1523/JNEUROSCI.1221-24.2024>

Abassi, E., & Papeo, L. (2024). Category-Selective Representation of Relationships in the Visual Cortex. *Journal of Neuroscience*. <https://doi.org/10.1523/JNEUROSCI.0250-23.2023>

Gandolfo, M., **Abassi, E.**, Balgova, E., Downing, P. E., Papeo, L., & Koldewyn, K. (2024). Converging evidence that left extrastriate body area supports visual sensitivity to social interactions. *Current Biology*. <https://doi.org/10.1016/j.cub.2023.12.009>

Abassi, E., & Papeo, L. (2022). Behavioral and neural markers of visual configural processing in social scene perception. *NeuroImage*. <https://doi.org/10.1016/j.neuroimage.2022.119506>

Spriet, C., **Abassi, E.**, Hochmann, J. R., & Papeo, L. (2022). Visual object categorization in infancy. *Proceedings of the National Academy of Sciences (PNAS)*. <https://doi.org/10.1073/pnas.2105866119>

Bellot, E., **Abassi, E.**, & Papeo, L. (2021). Moving toward versus away from another: how body motion direction changes the representation of bodies and actions in the visual cortex. *Cerebral Cortex*. <https://doi.org/10.1093/cercor/bhaa382>

Abassi, E., & Papeo, L. (2020). The representation of two-body shapes in the human visual cortex. *Journal of Neuroscience*. <https://doi.org/10.1523/JNEUROSCI.1378-19.2019>

Papeo, L., & **Abassi, E.** (2019). Seeing social events: The visual specialization for dyadic human–human interactions. *Journal of Experimental Psychology: Human Perception and Performance*. <https://doi.org/10.1037/xhp0000646>

Vaessen, M. J., **Abassi, E.**, Mancini, M., Camurri, A., & De Gelder, B. (2019). Computational feature analysis of body movements reveals hierarchical brain organization. *Cerebral Cortex*. <https://doi.org/10.1093/cercor/bhy228>